

what is MENTAL HEALTH?



According to the World Health Organization, mental health is defined as a state of well-being in which every individual realizes his or her own potential, can cope with the normal stresses of life, can work productively and fruitfully, and is able to make a contribution to her or his community.

So... what exactly does that mean?

Read these helpful FAQ's to get a better idea of what mental health is and how it impacts us.

How do I determine the state of my Mental Health?

Read the included resource
"What is Mental Illness?"

When does Mental Health matter?

No matter how old we are, mental health plays a part in much of our daily life. It provides the foundation for our thoughts, behavior and feelings and can impact how we react in stressful situations or during times of conflict, and also how we react during happy and joyous times. In these situations, good or bad, mental health can impact:

- How we feel
- What we say
- How we act
- How we cope and manage change
- How we interpret others behavior

So, when you wonder why you feel or acted a certain way, why your personal relationships are struggling (or not), why you can (or can't) manage your temper, your feelings or emotions, remember that all these things could be impacted by your mental health.

Where does Mental Health come from?

No one thing determines our mental health. Here's a look at the common factors that can work alone or together to impact our mental health.

- Biology (like our genes and our brain)
- Personal experiences and relationships
- Trauma or abuse
- Self Esteem
- Confidence
- Family situations, conflict, separation
- Family history of mental health problems
- Medical health or injury
- Substance abuse
- Emotional or physical abuse

References

www.who.int/features/factfiles/mental_health/en/
www.mentalhealth.gov/basics/what-is-mental-health
www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/mental-illness/symptoms-causes/syc-20374968

what is MENTAL ILLNESS?

It is not just one thing but is made of a wide collection of mental health conditions all with different symptoms. It is most generally characterized by changes in thinking, emotions, behaviour and relationships with others.

Mental Illness
can be a scary
topic that is
difficult to
understand

Where does Mental Health come from?

No one thing determines our mental health. Here's a look at the common factors that can work alone or together to impact our mental health.

- Biology (like our genes and our brain)
- Personal experiences and relationships
- Trauma or abuse
- Self Esteem
- Confidence
- Family situations, conflict, separation
- Family history of mental health problems
- Medical health or injury
- Substance abuse
- Emotional or physical abuse

Mental Illnesses can range from minor and only mildly impacting life and daily functions, to major such as depression, schizophrenia, and bipolar disorder. Some other mental illnesses include phobias, anxiety disorders, eating disorders, panic disorders, post traumatic stress disorder.

Mental Illness does not
discriminate against age, gender,
social status, income, religion, etc.

Mental illnesses can be treated and most individuals suffering can continue to function in their daily lives. If not treated, mental illness can seriously impact personal relationships, daily life, and can lead to isolation.

References

www.mentalhealth.gov/basics/what-is-mental-health
www.toronto.cmha.ca/understanding-mental-illness/
www.camh.ca/en/health-info/guides-and-publications/stigma



what are the **WARNING SIGNS?**

Many individuals have mental health concerns from time to time, but it's important to understand the common warning signs of mental illness and when to seek help.

It is very important to understand the common warning signs.

Here Are Some Common Warning Signs:

- Feeling very sad or withdrawn for more than two weeks
- Out-of-control, risk-taking behaviors
- Harming oneself or others, or making plans to do so
- Suicidal thoughts
- Overwhelming feeling of fear, worry, hopelessness, or feeling 'numb'
- Seeing or hearing things that are not real
- Sudden changes in mood, behavior, or personality
- Eating too much or too little, or a significant change in eating habits
- Sleeping too much or too little, or a significant change in sleeping habits
- Concentration problems
- Abusing drugs or alcohol, or using them more than usual
- Sudden change in usual activities or relationships
- Inability to manage normal daily tasks

References

www.mentalhealth.gov/basics/what-is-mental-health
www.nami.org/Learn-More/Know-the-Warning-Signs



how to GET HELP & SUPPORT OTHERS

How To Get Help?

If you feel that yourself, a friend or family member are suffering from mental illness, reach out immediately to someone you trust. You might reach out to a friend or family member, a teacher or coach, a mental health professional or a doctor.

If a friend or family member is suffering from mental illness, speak up & reach out.

IF YOU ARE WORRIED THAT YOURSELF, OR A FRIEND OR FAMILY MEMBER WILL HARM THEMSELVES OR OTHERS, TAKE ACTION IMMEDIATELY BY:

Kids Help Phone, 1-800-668-6868 (or Text CONNECT to 686868)

Victim Link 24 hour Crisis Support, 1-800-563-0808 (or Text to 604-836-6381)

KUU-US Crisis Line, 1-800-588-8717

KUU-U Child/Youth Crisis Line, 1-250-723-2040

Calling 911

How Can I Support Someone Suffering?

- Reach out and discuss it with them
- Tell them you are there for them
- Be present and listen to them
- Reassure them that you care
- Remind them that they can overcome this
- Reassure them that people love them
- Learn more about the specific mental illness together
- Be supportive and check in on them
- Reassure them that your relationship won't be changed by their mental health condition
- Avoid making judgements or being dismissive
- Include them in plans and outings
- Ask them how you can help

References

www.mentalhealth.gov/talk/friends-family-members

www.nami.org/Find-Support/Teens-Young-Adults/How-to-Help-a-Friend



what is STIGMA?

According to The Centre for Addiction and Mental Health (CAMH), stigma refers to negative attitudes (prejudice) and negative behaviour (discrimination) toward people with substance use and mental health problems.

When we internalize stigma, we cause ourselves to feel guilty or shameful about our mental health.

Individuals suffering from Mental Illness can often be hesitant to share their real thoughts and feelings because of the stigma associated with it, which can occur internally and externally.

When we internalize stigma, we cause ourselves to feel guilty or shameful about our mental health. Stigma can also come from external forces, where individuals with mental illnesses are discriminated against. Stigma can impact one's ability to gain employment, maintain relationships, maintain a safe home environment, feel accepted.

How Can We Get Rid of Stigma?

Everyone can make a difference. Here are some ways you can impact how mental illness is

- **EDUCATE YOURSELF AND OTHERS.**
Learn the FACTS associated with mental health and illness.
- **TALK ABOUT IT.**
Help make mental health a topic anyone can talk about
- **BE AWARE.**
Take caution, use facts, and be sensitive when speaking about mental health and illness.
- **SUPPORT YOURSELF AND OTHERS.**
Remind yourself & others that we all need people and professionals to lean on now & then.
- **BE INCLUSIVE.**
Don't exclude or discriminate.

References

www.camh.ca/en/health-info/guides-and-publications/stigma